Where Did Guru Nanak Travel?

A factual research brief on the traditional Udasis and the limits of historical certainty

Scope. Guru Nanak (1469–1539), founder of the Sikh tradition, is traditionally described as undertaking long missionary journeys called *udasis*. This report distinguishes between places strongly supported by early Sikh tradition and places whose itinerary or historicity remains uncertain.

Bottom line. The broadest and most consistent traditional itinerary reaches across the Indian subcontinent and into the Himalayan region and West Asia: east to Bengal and Assam, south to Sri Lanka, north toward Kashmir and the Himalayas, and west to Mecca, Medina, Baghdad and Afghanistan. Exact routes, dates, and some distant destinations cannot be established with modern historical confidence.

Direction / journey	Traditionally associated places	Historical assessment
Eastward Udasi	Punjab; Delhi; Panipat; Haridwar; Banaras/Varanasi; Prayag; Gaya/Patna; Bengal; Assam/Kamrup; Jagannath Puri; and other eastern Indian sites.	Visits to pilgrimage centres in India are among the better-supported elements of the tradition, but the precise sequence is reconstructed from later sources.
Southward journey	South India, including Rameshwaram and other pilgrimage centres; Sri Lanka/Ceylon (often called Singladip).	Sri Lanka is a major traditional destination. The detailed local itinerary and chronology are less certain.
Northern / Himalayan journey	Kashmir; Himalayan foothills; Ladakh; “Sumer Parbat” or Mount Sumeru in the tradition; sometimes Tibet and the region around Kailash–Manasarovar.	A northern journey and encounters with ascetics are prominent in early Sikh narratives. Identifying Sumeru with Kailash and assigning every listed Tibetan site are debated.
Western journey	Sindh and Balochistan; Mecca; Medina; Baghdad; Kabul; Peshawar and adjoining Afghan routes. Some later accounts add Syria, Palestine, Turkey, Iran and Central Asia.	Mecca, Medina and Baghdad are central to Sikh tradition, especially Bhai Gurdas and Janamsakhi narratives. The wider extensions are substantially less secure; modern scholarship disputes or qualifies parts of the Middle Eastern itinerary.
Punjab travels and Kartarpur	Talwandi/Nankana Sahib; Sultanpur Lodhi; Eminabad/Saidpur; Lahore; Multan; Pakpattan; Sialkot; Batala; Kartarpur and other Punjab locations.	Repeated movement in Punjab is historically plausible and consistent with the community’s early geography.

Reading the table. “Traditionally associated” does not mean every location is independently proven. The main evidence consists of Guru Nanak’s hymns, Bhai Gurdas’s writings, and Janamsakhi life narratives composed after his lifetime. These sources preserve important memory but also contain hagiographic and miraculous material.

What the Sources Say

Encyclopaedia Britannica states that it is certain Guru Nanak visited pilgrimage sites throughout India, while noting that little else can be established securely because the Janamsakhis were composed decades after his death and contain legendary material. Britannica's account of the Puratan tradition presents five trips: east, south to Sri Lanka, north into the Himalayas, west to Baghdad, Mecca and Medina, followed by travel within Punjab. [1]

Gurinder Singh Mann's scholarly assessment emphasizes that the evidence must be reconstructed from several early Sikh sources rather than from a single biography. He reports that the Puratan Janamsakhi describes four long missionary journeys after Kartarpur was established: toward Sindh in the south, the Himalayan foothills in the north, Mecca in the west, and the present-day Peshawar area in the northwest. Mann also notes that later Janamsakhis expand the eastern travels to Assam and Puri and elaborate the routes. [2]

The Punjabi University *Atlas: Travels of Guru Nanak* maps traditional routes through South Asia, Sri Lanka, the Himalayas, West Asia and Afghanistan. Its authors explicitly caution that no first-hand sources survive, that the Janamsakhi accounts vary, and that route reconstruction necessarily includes informed inference. [3]

Geographical reach

On the traditional map, Guru Nanak's journeys covered modern-day India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, with western routes extending into Saudi Arabia, Iraq and Afghanistan. Some traditions further place him in Iran, Syria, Turkey, Palestine or Central Asia, but these claims should be labelled "later or disputed," not presented as settled fact.

Representative route illustration: Sultanpur Lodhi → Delhi and the Gangetic plain → Bengal/Assam → Jagannath Puri and South India → Sri Lanka; then north through the Himalayan region; then west through Sindh/Balochistan → Mecca and Medina → Baghdad → Kabul/Peshawar → Kartarpur. This is a synthesis of traditional routes, not a verified modern itinerary.

Historical cautions

1. The term *Udasi* refers to a long missionary journey in Sikh tradition; different sources number and organize the journeys differently.

2. Place names changed over time. For example, Talwandi is now Nankana Sahib, Saidpur is commonly identified with Eminabad, and Ceylon is Sri Lanka.

3. A shared tradition across multiple Sikh sources increases historical interest but does not by itself prove every episode or exact route.

4. Stories such as the moving mihrab at Mecca are theological narratives illustrating Guru Nanak's message that the Divine is not confined to one direction; they should not be treated as itinerary evidence.

Sources

[1] Encyclopaedia Britannica, “Guru Nanak,” written by William Hewat McLeod and fact-checked by Britannica Editors, updated 25 Nov. 2025. It summarizes the evidentiary limits of the Janamsakhis and the traditional east, south, north and west journeys.

[2] Gurinder Singh Mann, “Guru Nanak’s Life and Legacy: An Appraisal,” *Journal of Punjab Studies* 17, nos. 1–2, University of California, Santa Barbara. The article discusses early Sikh sources, the formation of the Janamsakhi traditions, and competing reconstructions of the journeys.

[3] Fauja Singh and Kirpal Singh, *Atlas: Travels of Guru Nanak*, Punjabi University, Patiala, 1976. The atlas compares routes derived from Bhai Gurdas, Puratan, Meharban and Bala traditions and explicitly describes the limitations of reconstructing a biography from later sources.

Research note: This PDF is intended as a careful introductory research brief. It reports traditional Sikh travel claims while separating them from conclusions that can be established more confidently through historical criticism.